

Question for a Uni Design Project: Is the massive energy footprint of AI actually on your radar?

Posted by u/TalNix77 • • 0 points • 3 comments

Hi everyone,

I'm a design student researching the "invisible" energy consumption of AI for a university project.

While the utility of tools like ChatGPT is obvious, the physical resources required to run them are massive. Studies suggest that a single generative AI query can consume significantly more energy than a standard web search (some estimates range from 10x to 25x more).

I'm looking for honest perspectives on this:

1. **Awareness:** Before reading this, were you actually aware of the scale of energy difference between a standard search and an AI prompt? Or is that completely "invisible" in your daily usage?
2. **Impact on Usage:** Does the energy intensity play any role in how you use these tools? Or is the utility simply the only factor that matters for your workflow?
3. **Value vs. Waste:** Do you view this high energy consumption as a fair investment for the results you get, or does the current technology feel inefficient to you?

I'm trying to get a realistic picture of whether this topic actually plays a role in users' minds or if performance is the priority.

Thanks for your input.

Comments

u/FlightFit335 • 1 points • 2025-12-09 00:04 UTC

The whole OMG slant is an irrational bias. The power demand for data centers have put a spot light on the inefficiency of wind and solar power that has been poorly mandated.

Will Ai consume a large percentage? Yes, until nuclear plants built with modern technology are built and brought online. Then the percentage of use will be a mute point. Plus the efficiency of compute will continue to improve.

This increase in demand is a net positive in the long run.

u/radish-salad • 1 points • 2025-12-06 08:17 UTC

Yep. I've seen the towns these data centers are wrecking and the bills they're skyrocketing. I also boycott nestle for similar reasons. we already use colossal amounts of energy and resources and there's no reason to make it infinitely worse. I feel like it's such a stupid frivolous waste of resources, so I don't use ai. don't need it, don't want it.

u/Ordinary_Objective63 • 2 points • 2025-12-06 00:39 UTC

Data centers (all data centers in the US not just the AI ones) used 4.4% of all electricity in the US in 2023. AI data centers accounted for 5-15% of that usage. So .22 to .66%

Yes, they use more compared 1:1. But we already use a lot of electricity for other data centers. If AI vanished. It would lower our energy usage by that amount.

It is predicted to use more. It is also predicted it can use less by assigning domain specific tasks (such as cancer research, or mapping the ocean floor, instead of general purpose learning. It is also predicted it can use less as ai specific hardware is developed.

The US is a country that has the least sustainable transportation infrastructure in the world. You want me to worry about .66% of the electricity when all the people posting on social media, streaming social media, and online gaming used more?

Anytime everyone knows the same "did you know it did this?" It is always out of context, overstated, and not compared to something relevant.

u/meme560 • 2 points • 2025-12-05 23:50 UTC

what's worse me driving my 30 year old car with a v8 to work everyday or using chat gpt to write a 20 page essay?